

Reading a People Into Being

A one-page field guide to constitutive moves in secession and restoration rhetoric.

Working draft, subject to revision.

For communication strategists, civic and deliberation practitioners, and analysts watching sovereignty and restoration movements. Three reads, each with a tell and a caution.

Read 1 — Recognize the people-building move

A constitutive appeal does not argue to an existing audience. It tells the audience who they already are. Listen for transhistorical identity (“we have always been...”), collective agency (“we act as one”), and an embedded end (“and so we must...”).

- Tell: the conclusion is smuggled inside the description. Accepting “who you are” has already conceded “what you want.”
- Caution: answering the conclusion on the merits misses the move. The work happened in the identity sentence, one step earlier.

Read 2 — Spot the telos held as leverage

When the substrate is thin, the promised end detaches from the identity and becomes a bargaining chip. Alberta is the clean example: a “sovereignty within a united Canada” law, a ballot that asks only to begin a process, and polling where the grievance identity stays high while support for actual exit falls.¹

- Tell: the movement’s own instruments soften the end (procedural questions, non-binding votes, “within” clauses). The exit is being held, not pursued.
- Caution: treat a detachable telos as negotiating posture. Engaging the identity grievance directly can lower the temperature the exit threat was raising.

Read 3 — Read the prior-people collision

Constitutive appeals assume open ground. Where a prior people holds a juridical claim, the appeal meets a limit it cannot reword. Treaties that predate a jurisdiction, and courts that enforce a duty to consult, are not rhetorical obstacles. They are structural ones.²

- Tell: a movement routes around, rather than answers, an existing treaty or rights-holder. That silence marks the wall.
- Caution: do not model the prior people as a stakeholder to be persuaded. In Québec (Cree, 1995) and Alberta (King’s Bench, 2026) the prior claim decided outcomes that rhetoric did not.³

Quick diagnostic

| Variable | Question to ask | What it predicts |

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| Vector | Does the telos point forward (found) or backward (restore)? | How the “people” will narrate legitimacy. |

| Substrate | Ethnos-thick or grievance-thin? | Whether the telos will hold or detach. |

| Prior claim | Is the ground already constituted under law? | Whether rhetoric meets a structural limit.

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Notes

- Angus Reid Institute, 2026; Alberta Sovereignty within a United Canada Act; CBC on the Oct. 19 question.

- Numbered Treaties 6–8; Athabasca Chipewyan First Nation v Alberta (CEO), 2026; Reference re Secession of Quebec \[1998\].

- Cree counter-referendum, 1995.

Citations and links in the Literature Review.